intrigues of the dynastic court rather than on the bureaucratic labyrinth that sustains – and sometimes curbs – the dynasty's power.

LET'S KILL ALL THE LAWYERS

The difficulty of depicting and understanding bureaucratic realities has had unfortunate results. On the one hand, it leaves people feeling helpless in the face of harmful powers they do not understand, like the hero of *The Trial*. On the other hand, it also leaves people with the impression that bureaucracy is a malign conspiracy, even in cases when it is in fact a benign force providing us with health care, security and justice.

In the sixteenth century, Ludovico Ariosto described the allegorical figure of Discord as a woman who walks around in a cloud of 'sheaves of summonses and writs, cross-examinations and powers of attorney, and great piles of glosses, counsel's opinions and precedents – all of which tended to the greater insecurity of impoverished folk. In front and behind her and on either side she was hemmed in by notaries, attorneys and barristers.'[46]

In his description of Jack Cade's Rebellion (1450) in *Henry VI*, *Part 2*, Shakespeare has a commoner rebel called Dick the Butcher take the antipathy to bureaucracy to its logical conclusion. Dick has a plan to establish a better social order. 'The first thing we do,' advises Dick, 'let's kill all the lawyers.' The rebel leader, Jack Cade, runs with Dick's proposal in a forceful attack on bureaucracy and in particular on written documents: 'Is not this a lamentable thing, that of the skin of an innocent lamb should be made parchment? That parchment, being scribbled o'er, should undo a man? Some say the bee stings: but I say, 'tis the bee's wax; for I did but seal once to a thing, and I was never mine own man since.' Just then the rebels capture a clerk and accuse him of being able to write and read. After a short interrogation that establishes his 'crime', Cade orders his men, 'Hang him with his pen and inkhorn about his neck.'[47]

Seventy years prior to Jack Cade's Rebellion, during the even bigger 1381 Peasants' Revolt, the rebels focused their ire not only on flesh-and-blood bureaucrats but also on their documents, destroying numerous archives and burning court rolls, charters and administrative and legal records. In one incident, they made a bonfire of the archives of the University of Cambridge. An old woman named Margery Starr scattered the